

Alkali Metals

After hydrogen (H) – which is in a group of its own – the first column of the periodic table contains the alkali metals. This group gets its name from the way the elements react with water. These vigorous reactions always produce acid-attacking compounds called alkalis. None of the alkali metals are ever found in a pure form in nature. The first three metals are common in many minerals, while the last three are rarer.



Atomic structure

The atoms of all alkali metals have just one electron in their outer shell. Alkali metal atoms are among the biggest of all atoms.



Physical properties

These metals are soft enough to be cut with a knife. They are all silvery and very shiny when clean.



Chemical properties

Alkali metals are highly reactive. They form bonds with other elements, giving away their single outer electron.



Compounds

These metals react with water to form compounds called hydroxides. They react easily with halogens to form salts, such as sodium chloride.